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“We Too Deserve a Place in the Sun”: The Politics of Transvestite Identity in Weimar Germany

Katie Sutton

ABSTRACT

Cross-dressing took on new political meanings in Germany's Weimar Republic, with the emergence of organizations and periodicals aimed at promoting the interests of self-identified “transvestites.” This new sexological category, developed by Magnus Hirschfeld in 1910, formed the basis for a shared sense of identity and belonging among individuals who identified as members of the “opposite” sex. Drawing on the experiences of the homosexual emancipation movement and discourses of bourgeois respectability, middle-class transvestites came together to demand legal and social recognition, including acknowledgement of “transsexual” desires. Their efforts represent a critical but forgotten moment in the history of transgender political activism.

Introduction

In late 1929, in the city of Essen in Germany's industrial Ruhr valley, forty-two-year-old male-to-female transvestite Toni (Anton) Simon, dressed in a nice frock and high heels, turned up in a court packed with spectators eager to see how she would defend herself against charges of “gross mischief” (*groben Unfug*) for going out in public dressed in women's clothing.¹ Simon's case was all but dismissed by the court, with the judge conceding, despite a hundred-mark fine, that if the German police were so progressive as to issue “transvestite certificates” (*Transvestitenscheine*) to select individuals to protect them from arrest while cross-dressing in public spaces, then the court had little option but to follow suit.² Despite this relatively harmonious outcome, Simon's day in court has broader implications for the history of sexuality in early twentieth-century Germany, for it points to a growing level of public awareness

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surrounding the newly defined sexological category of the “transvestite.” With increasing numbers of individuals identifying themselves as “transvestites” and seeking new forms of community based on this identification, 1920s Germany represents a crucial, but often forgotten moment in the history of transgender political organization.

The term “transvestism” (*Transvestitismus*) was coined in 1910 by pioneering German sex researcher and political activist Magnus Hirschfeld, and publicized via his lengthy study of the same year, *Die Transvestiten* (Transvestites). It formed part of a larger shift among sexologists away from nineteenth-century theories of sex-gender “inversion,” which viewed same-sex attraction and cross-gender characteristics as two sides of the same coin, and toward an understanding of “homosexuality” defined primarily by sexual object preference.³ Because this latter category could not account for cases where cross-gendered characteristics were the primary “symptom,” researchers in the early twentieth century began to develop theories of what they variously described as “sexo-aesthetic inversion”/“eonism” (Havelock Ellis), “transmutism” (Ferdinand von Karsch-Haack), or the “drive for sex transformation” (*Geschlechtsumwandlungstrieb*, Max Marcuse).⁴ It was Hirschfeld’s term, however, that proved most popular in interwar Germany, not only among scientists, but also among males who identified as women and females who identified as men.⁵

Questions of transvestite identity and politics have been largely overlooked in histories of the Weimar period, often gaining only marginal coverage even in studies of sexual subcultures. The most important exception is Rainer Herrn’s groundbreaking study *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, which focuses on early twentieth-century sexological and surgical approaches to transvestism and transsexuality, as well as surveying questions of legal status and subcultural organization.⁶ Despite this overwhelming neglect, there is evidence that self-identified “transvestites” constituted an increasingly vocal presence in German cultural life from the mid-1920s, not only organizing into associations with links to the contemporary homosexual rights movement, but also producing newspapers and magazines aimed at entertaining, encouraging, and furthering the political rights of “like-minded” individuals. Toni Simon’s case, for example, provoked responses from as far away as Berlin, where commentators in this new transvestite media attacked the court’s “provincial” ignorance of scientific research showing transvestites to be “perfectly normal,” debated the wisdom of Simon’s decision to appear in the stands in feminine attire, and reflected on the broader problems facing transvestites in German society.

By showing how individuals in 1920s Germany used such new media in order to negotiate what it meant to inhabit a “transvestite” identity, this article challenges the claim of historians Vern and Bonnie Bullough that “there is no evidence in Western culture of what might be called a transvestite consciousness before the last part of the twentieth century.”⁷ Focusing on publications created by and for transvestites enables an analytical shift away from the sexological and medical frameworks that continue

to shape much scholarship on transvestism in the early twentieth century, and sheds light on the aspirations, concerns, and self-image of individuals whose gender identity did not align with their birth sex.⁸ The middle-class organizations and publications that began to appear during the latter half of the Weimar Republic constituted what might, I suggest, be usefully described as a transvestite “counterpublic,” a term which, as Michael Warner explains, not only expresses a relationship of conflict and subordination within a broader public sphere, but is also bound up with processes of identity formation: “participation in such a public is one of the ways its members’ identities are formed and transformed.”⁹ In Weimar Germany, trans-identifying individuals were not only starting to communicate with each other outside of private friendship networks and underground clubs on the basis of what they increasingly perceived as a shared *Veranlagung*, or disposition; they also, I shall argue, drew on notions of bourgeois respectability in order to formulate claims for political and legal recognition—what we might term “transvestite citizenship”—within the larger context of German public life.

Transvestites and the Law

Advocates of transvestite rights in 1920s Germany were navigating largely uncharted waters. While they could draw on the experiences of the homosexual emancipation movement, which since the turn of the century had campaigned against Paragraph 175 of the Criminal Code (RStGB) outlawing male homosexual acts, transvestites lacked a similarly prominent legal hurdle.¹⁰ The main hindrance to public cross-dressing was the nineteenth-century laws concerning gross mischief and creating a public nuisance (Paragraphs 360/11 and 183, respectively, of the RStGB), which allowed for up to six weeks’ imprisonment or a fine of 150 marks. Because this could only be applied when a “public nuisance” was genuinely seen to have occurred, cross-dressing individuals who successfully “passed” on the streets as members of their nonbirth sex were theoretically given the green light. In reality, however, it left many individuals vulnerable to the arbitrary decisions of, and occasional harassment by, members of the police forces, who were often keen to exercise their extensive regulatory powers.¹¹

As a result, a number of individuals—it is unclear how many exactly—sought protection in the form of the aforementioned “transvestite certificates,” documents which showed that the bearer was known to police and was not guilty of *Unfug* if apprehended while cross-dressing. The issuing of such certificates was at the discretion of local police authorities, but transvestite “passports” could also be issued which allowed the bearer to travel unimpeded between jurisdictions. The first known example of such a certificate’s being issued in Germany was that of Katharina T., who appealed to Berlin’s police president in 1908/1909 for permission both to continue wearing male clothing, and to adopt a masculine name. On the basis of a joint expert report by Magnus Hirschfeld and psychoanalyst Karl Abraham, the first request was

granted, but the second was denied “for formal legal reasons.” Sources suggest that Katharina T.’s experience was not unusual: while the certificates seem to have been reasonably easy to obtain with the appropriate medical documentation (Toni Simon also received one), individuals who additionally sought to change their names were, at least initially, less likely to meet with success.¹² Hirschfeld’s role as a medical expert in this case is also no coincidence: he strongly advocated transvestites’ applying for certificates as a means of legal protection, advising them to include a medical report and photographs of themselves in male and female clothing.¹³

The liberalization of police attitudes in the Weimar period further improved the situation for transvestites. As recent studies of prostitution have shown, Germany’s police forces at this period were required to cede some of their older authoritarian powers to new agents of the democratic welfare state, such as social workers.¹⁴ Even though many police officials continued to see their role as defenders of inherited moral values,¹⁵ this relaxation of police bureaucracy meant that applicants were now generally permitted to change their names to more gender-neutral alternatives such as “Toni,” “Gert,” or “Alex.”¹⁶ Furthermore, a 1922 procedural guideline issued by Berlin police headquarters reiterated that wearing the clothing of the opposite sex was not an illegal act, and could only be grounds for arrest where gross mischief or prostitution could also be proven:

Apart from male prostitution, transvestism in general has no criminal significance. The widespread public opinion that the disguised individuals are generally criminals in disguise (pickpockets, spies, pimps, etc.) is obsolete. With regard to the male transvestites, recent experience shows that even the formerly taken-for-granted view that men in women’s clothing are all homosexuals is no longer tenable. . . . On the basis of this insight emerges a duty of gentle treatment [*schonenden Behandlung*] of transvestites, as long as they are not engaged in male prostitution.¹⁷

This heavy-handed approach toward cross-dressing male prostitutes was nothing new: as Hans Ostwald’s account of imperial Berlin indicates, they had long attracted police attention in the context of blackmail cases.¹⁸ The guidelines go on to state that cross-dressers need only be reported if not in possession of a certificate. While instances of police bullying continued to be reported in the subcultural media,¹⁹ this relatively liberal official stance provided an important precondition for the emergence of a transvestite counterpublic in the late 1920s.

Creating a Transvestite Counterpublic

Processes of industrialization and urbanization have historically been shown to promote the development of sexual subcultures, creating the conditions for new forms of social and political organization away from the traditional ties of family and

village.²⁰ These forces combined with the liberalized political climate of Germany's Weimar Republic to help foster a mass homosexual rights movement, which was particularly strong in larger cities such as Berlin and Hamburg.²¹ At the forefront of this movement were two competing organizations, the League of Human Rights (*Bund für Menschenrechte*, BfM), led by publisher Friedrich Radszuweit, and the German Friendship Association (*Deutscher Freundschafts-Verband*, DFV), with close links to Hirschfeld's Institute for Sexual Sciences in Berlin, and each of these organizations sponsored affiliated transvestite associations and publications. In 1927 the BfM established a short-lived "Coalition of Transvestites" (*Zusammenschluß der Transvestiten*), which met weekly in Berlin in the "Taverne," followed in 1929 by the foundation of a "Special Transvestite Group" (*Sondergruppe Transvestiten*).²² In 1930 the DFV followed suit, overseeing the foundation of the "D'Eon Organization" (*Vereinigung D'Eon*), which had rooms at Hirschfeld's Institute.²³ Despite their metropolitan location, these organizations caused excitement across the country, with one reader of a transvestite magazine declaring: "Finally the first step has been taken! The hearts beat loudly in South Germany and send you a hearty 'good luck' for your foundation."²⁴ They provided real spaces in which trans-identifying individuals—particularly those who lived in or were visiting the cities—could meet, change their clothes, listen to lectures on relevant scientific or legal questions, seek advice, or relax at events such as fashion parades or balls. However, they struggled to gain and maintain members, not least due to the fear of many of being "outed" as cross-dressers to families, work colleagues, or friends.²⁵

Reaching out to a larger public were the new transvestite media (hereafter TV media)—magazine columns, supplements, and entire periodicals devoted specifically to transvestite issues. Drawing readers from across Germany and sometimes beyond, these periodicals helped to combat readers' isolation by suggesting a shared experience even in the absence of traditional forms of community contact, for as one reader from Düsseldorf lamented, "I miss all contact with like-minded individuals with whom I could speak about these things and socialize."²⁶ Although they were affiliated with the membership organizations, these periodicals enjoyed a more stable existence: the two longest-running columns, "Die Welt der Transvestiten" (Transvestites' world) and "Der Transvestit" (The transvestite) appeared from 1924 to 1933 and 1926 to 1932, respectively. These columns and supplements were attached to magazines otherwise catering to homosexual women, in what was probably a concession to financial realities as well as reflecting a degree of structural crossover between transvestite and female homosexual organizations; this also meant, however, that they faced the same difficulties with censorship as the homosexual periodicals under the 1926 *Schmutz und Schund* legislation.²⁷ The TV media published a range of historical and scientific articles, commentaries on legal and social injustices, opinion and self-help columns on practical issues such as dress and relationships, and autobiographical vignettes,

short stories, and poems. In addition, the late Weimar period saw at least one attempt to produce a publication entirely for transvestites, *Das 3. Geschlecht* (The third sex); this disappeared after approximately five issues, however, apparently failing to attract enough subscribers in difficult economic times.²⁸

Just as the large homosexual rights organizations of the Weimar period, as studies have shown, were oriented primarily toward middle-class men and women in terms of membership demographics, political strategies, social activities, and publications, the transvestite organizations and periodicals were decidedly bourgeois in outlook.²⁹ Middle-class values of respectability and citizenship shaped the political agenda, with contributors drawing on the powerful language of national inclusion in formulating their demands for legal and social acceptance. “We too have a right to a place in the sun,” declared Simon shortly after her court hearing, earnestly echoing a phrase associated with Germany’s nationalist and colonialist ambitions of the Wilhelmine era, and she was certainly not the only one to voice such far-reaching demands.³⁰

Setting the Boundaries: A Politics of Respectability

As a cultural figure who blurred the boundaries between male and female, although in ways that differed from older concepts of the hermaphrodite or androgyne, the transvestite could easily have been interpreted as a threat to the traditional roles and structures on which German society and politics were based: “Nationalism and respectability assigned everyone his place in life, man and woman, normal and abnormal, native and foreigner; any confusion between these categories threatened chaos and loss of control.”³¹ Seemingly aware of this challenge, commentators in the Weimar TV media embraced a politics of respectability and invisibility as the path to claiming a place within German public life. As *Vereinigung D'Eon* leader Marie Weis announced following a 1930 meeting, only when the conditions of transvestite respectability had been achieved would it be possible to publicly identify with the label “transvestite” and fight for political rights on that basis.³²

Lacking the kind of clear legal hurdle that had mobilized the homosexual rights movement and forced coalitions between otherwise divided groups, the transvestite organizations formulated their political agendas in broad terms, placing greater emphasis on “enlightening” the public about the transvestite “condition” than on party politics. In 1927, the BfM’s Lina Es thus declared two key goals of the Coalition of Transvestites to be the “fight against public opinion” and “saving the lives and health of the lonely and desperate.”³³ Similarly, the *Vereinigung D'Eon*’s “ten-point working program” included cooperating with the daily press and producing an independent newspaper, in addition to establishing an advocacy organization and legal, medical, marital, and career advice centers.³⁴ The TV media sought to complement such organizational goals by providing an alternative perspective to the mainstream daily papers, which they criticized for perpetuating negative stereotypes of transvestites

by focusing on particularly crass examples of cross-dressing criminals: "With every 'case' of indecency that is made public they condemn all of us out of hand and speak of perversities and demand death and the gallows."³⁵ Although low circulation figures suggest that their influence in this respect was limited,³⁶ these publications also functioned as an important forum for promoting political activism within the emerging transvestite counterpublic, with readers encouraged to flood the authorities with applications for transvestite certificates, and to take responsibility for spreading the message within their own lives, by "confessing" their predisposition to spouses, families, and work colleagues (the phrase *sich bekennen* was frequently used).³⁷

Commentators in the TV media thus sought to establish transvestites as respectable, upstanding citizens, challenging the kind of moral condemnation they saw as leading all too often to depression or suicide. Yet because of this insistence on bourgeois respectability, these sources reveal very little about other demographic groups of transgendered individuals in this period—the cross-dressing male prostitutes, cabarettists, or entertainers, for example, who moved more within the working-class, bohemian, or "underworld" spaces of Germany's cities in the 1920s, and who may well have actively rejected such bourgeois values. Although these individuals left few archival traces other than arrest records or as the subjects of sexological studies, it is important to remember that the spectrum of transgendered experience in 1920s Germany was far more diverse than that represented in the TV media. The latter's adherence to middle-class values reflects the social contexts of its contributors, many of whom identified not only as transvestites, but also as successful businessmen, husbands, or fathers, and whose levels of education and financial security enabled them to participate as producers and consumers of new media forms.

For members of this middle-class transvestite public, "respectability" involved conforming to dominant standards of appearance, behavior, and morality. This included establishing themselves as patriotic citizens: a lengthy article series on "Transvestites in the World War" challenged stereotypes of cross-dressing spies and draft dodgers with stories of bravery, stamina, and national duty.³⁸ The respectability imperative was also used to justify the marginalization of nonconforming individuals, as leaders of the transvestite associations repeatedly stressed that membership was open only to "impeccable," "trustworthy," and "genuine" transvestites, whereas "dishonest elements" were to be excluded absolutely. We can thus extend to these organizations George Mosse's argument that, "even feminists, homosexuals, and lesbians proclaimed their adherence to the basic norms and stereotypes of respectability, wanting only to bend the bars of their cage, not to unhinge them."³⁹

Two of the clearest grounds for exclusion were prostitution and criminality—occupations associated with the poverty, immorality, and degeneracy that many intellectuals of this period viewed as flourishing among the lower classes.⁴⁰ Cross-dressing male prostitutes, the aforementioned bane of the Berlin police, were considered a

particularly serious threat to transvestite respectability: bluntly dismissed as the “scum of humanity” and as “morally inferior,” they were also marginalized linguistically as *Auchtransvestiten* (“also-transvestites”). Cross-dressing criminals were likewise denied the status of “true” transvestites and assumed to be motivated only by financial incentive: “such subjects have nothing in common with transvestism and must . . . constantly be fought against in the most energetic manner possible”; “we refuse all association with them, because their demeanor is dangerous to all other genuine transvestites.”⁴¹

Such merciless exclusion of “undesirable” elements also characterized the homosexual rights movement at this period: Marti Lybeck’s research shows that working-class barflies, street prostitutes, and upper-class bohemians were all often given short shrift in middle-class female homosexual organizations such as the *Damenklub Violetta* (“Violetta Ladies’ Club”), which consciously modeled themselves after the nineteenth-century *Vereine* to create an alternative to the “disorderly” spaces of bars and clubs.⁴² Readers of the TV media were similarly advised to frequent only “respectable” establishments free of drugs and prostitution, “if they want to avoid being denounced as riff-raff,” while the *Vereinigung D’Eon*’s Marie Weis loudly lamented the existence of venues that attracted just as many “alleged” as “genuine” transvestite customers.⁴³ A clear privileging of middle-class values is at work in such statements: from a fear of arrest and loss of social status if found to be frequenting the “wrong” venues, to a preference for bourgeois notions of *Kultur* and personal betterment over “mere” entertainment and pleasure.

Yet simply steering clear of prostitutes and lower-class establishments was not enough to satisfy the requirements of transvestite respectability; one also had to conform to dominant standards of dress and self-presentation:

When we demand that the public acknowledge us, then we have the duty to dress and conduct ourselves publicly in an inconspicuous manner. . . . At home each person can do as they choose and as they consider right, but in public they must conform.⁴⁴

This required both passing the test of gender authenticity, and meeting the demands of contemporary, unadorned bourgeois fashion: “The simplest dress is, in our case, often the most elegant.” Middle-class transvestite commentators bluntly rejected any clothing or accessories they considered excessively opulent, gaudy, or dated, such as corsets, costume rings, or oversized earrings, even as such fashions continued to be favored by female impersonators and entertainers.⁴⁵ Such attitudes amounted to a policing of one’s cross-dressing peers based on the ability to “pass” in public as a respectable middle-class lady (female-to-male transvestites, on the other hand, were

generally considered able to fly under the radar of the “masculinized” female fashions so prominent in mid-1920s Germany⁴⁶).

There were, of course, important practical reasons for such a judgmental approach, for successful “passing” represented an effective means of protection against physical and verbal harassment or arrest, as the following commentator acknowledged:

As hard as it is for us to suppress our instinct, I nonetheless advise all transvestites to only allow themselves to be seen in the clothing of the other sex when they are utterly certain that they will come into conflict with neither the police nor the broader public.⁴⁷

Accordingly, transvestites were advised to seek out sympathetic women who could mentor them in the finer details of feminine aesthetics, or to model themselves after the transvestite fashion shows organized by the BfM. Had contributors to the Weimar TV media decided to challenge rather than conform to bourgeois standards of propriety and dress, they might have opened up their publications to a much broader spectrum of transgender identifications. Their failure to do so created something of a paradox, as demands for legal and social recognition were formulated on the condition that the subjects themselves disappear from public view—a problem that has continued to plague transgender politics in the decades since, as Sandy Stone observed when she described the difficulties in generating a “true, effective and representational counterdiscourse” when one is programmed to “fade into the ‘normal’ population as soon as possible.”⁴⁸

The establishment of safe spaces in which members of transvestite organizations could cross-dress and socialize without fear of social sanction provided a counterweight to this advocacy of cautious public-sphere behavior. As well as clubrooms and balls, by the late 1920s there was even talk of setting up an exclusive summer holiday residence. Such spaces formed an important addition to the metropolitan bar scene, where patrons entering or leaving establishments had to be perpetually on the alert. One eyewitness described, for example, how as a “joke,” two police officers waited outside the Berlin transvestite club “Mikado,” only to arrest a couple of youths in female evening dress the moment they came out onto the street.⁴⁹ At the more famous clubs such as Berlin’s “Eldorado,” patrons also had to put up with being the main attraction for gawking tourists keen to experience the city’s risqué nightlife. On the other hand, bars and clubs provided spaces for more extravagant, performative, and openly homosexual expressions of transvestite identity, attracting artists, emigrants, and actors, among others. As Andreas Sternweiler observes, those cabarettists and performers who were able to make a living in such clubs embodied the dreams of many transvestites, forced by financial necessity and social norms to limit their

cross-dressing to the evening hours.⁵⁰ Larger cities such as Berlin, Hamburg, and Cologne could boast a number of transvestite-friendly entertainment venues (sometimes combined with homosexual clubs) in this period. In Cologne's "Dornröschen," for example, female impersonators "Tilla" and "Resi" reportedly livened the atmosphere with their "Salomé number" and "Carmen dance"; in Düsseldorf "Hubertine" was a popular feature in homosexual clubs before the Nazi seizure of power; while in Berlin the clubs "Silhouette," "Taverne," "Hansi-Bar," "Monokel-Diele," and "Café Dorian Gray" catered to a wide demographic range, from prostitutes to the smart set.⁵¹

The Sex/Gender Politics of the Weimar Transvestite Organizations

Setting boundaries around "respectable" spaces, dress, and behavior was thus key to establishing a sense of shared middle-class transvestite identity, but class norms were not the only standard by which individuals were measured. Female-to-male and homosexual transvestites were likewise sidelined, as were individuals who voiced what would now be termed "transsexual" desires. Although the existence of female-to-male transvestites was acknowledged in generalist articles, autobiographical accounts were only rarely published, in contrast with the large number of narratives of male-to-female experience.⁵² To an extent, this imbalance reflected the ambiguous position of female transvestites within scientific discourse: because they were understood to be almost exclusively homosexual, they threatened to blur sexologists' neat categorical divisions (consequently, Hirschfeld included only one biological female among his seventeen case studies in *Die Transvestiten*).⁵³ This perceived crossover between female-to-male transvestite and female homosexual identifications was widely accepted within Weimar subcultural circles, reflected not only in the fact that these groups shared the same magazines, and often also similar masculine fashions, but also in the person of leader Lotte/Lothar Hahm, who at various points fronted both the BfM's transvestite and its homosexual women's organizations.⁵⁴ On the other hand, not all masculine-identifying homosexual women were pleased about being viewed as cross-dressers: "I hereby declare that we are not transvestites, with only a few exceptions. . . . It is only the masculine touch that we emphasize."⁵⁵ Such disagreements over the place of trans-identifying females within the homosexual and transvestite subcultures reflect a diversity of "masculine" identifications, and can be seen as an early foreshadowing of the "border wars" between transgender and "butch" lesbian identities that continues to occupy queer scholarship today.⁵⁶

Male homosexual transvestites were likewise largely excluded from the terms of 1920s transvestite citizenship, and—following the argumentation of the sexologists—frequently disregarded as only a minor percentage of the transvestite population.⁵⁷ They were doubly marginalized within many of the homosexual organizations of this period, with leaders such as Adolf Brand, Benedikt Friedländer, and even Friedrich Radszuweit openly proclaiming "masculinist" values in an attempt to distance

themselves from powerful cultural stereotypes of effeminacy, weakness, and perversion.⁵⁸ Within the TV media, the pressure to establish transvestites as respectable *heterosexual* subjects (i.e., as biological males who desired women) is seen in the following, highly typical disclaimers: “I would like to add that I am not of a homosexual disposition”; “My own sexual drive is directed toward women, i.e., I am not homosexual (as most of my fellow sisters in earlier articles in the ‘Freundin’ describe, transvestism has nothing to do with homosexuality).”⁵⁹ The homosexual “taint” was a thorn in the side of heterosexual husbands and fathers who, while identifying as “transvestite”—an identification that, for them, entailed discrete periods of feminine dress and behavior—viewed themselves as “normal” and “manly” citizens in other spheres of their lives. Accordingly, some of the most popular discussions in the TV media were on explicitly heterosexual topics, such as how to find an understanding wife. In such ways, notions of hegemonic masculinity continued to define hierarchies of value even within a subculture whose one shared point of identification was its challenge to gender normativity. Despite being ostracized within the broader society for their cross-dressing, these commentators nonetheless claimed a power inherent in their identities as heterosexual bourgeois men in order to condemn homosexual transvestites as “excessively” feminine, and impose “proper” gendered roles and styles on the larger transvestite population.⁶⁰

Yet this marginalization of homosexual voices did not go completely uncontested, with a few commentators criticizing exclusionary moves by heterosexual transvestites as instances of hypocritical intolerance and as the main hindrance to a unified transvestite identity and politics. “That is how it is, they demand full understanding for themselves, but don’t even have enough tact to respect other people’s idiosyncrasies,” argued one; “For us the key question must be the achievement of social recognition of our disposition and the associated consequences, and not the problematics of erotic relationships,” insisted another.⁶¹ A fiery debate on this issue took place at a 1929 BfM meeting called to debate the benefits of establishing a separate transvestite group rather than continuing to organize under the auspices of existing homosexual organizations. Despite some attendees’ expressing a willingness to put aside differences of sexual orientation, it was agreed that a mixed heterosexual/homosexual transvestite organization would face too many difficulties to support more than one event per month.⁶²

A final group perceived as endangering the fragile edifice of respectability was individuals whose “transvestite” desires went beyond external appearances to encompass a longing for permanent physical transformation. Hirschfeld had described such individuals as “total” or “extreme” transvestites, for the term “transsexual,” although coined in 1923, was not yet in common use.⁶³ Marie Weis was particularly vocal on this point, “I beg consideration of the effect that some of the desires in question here must have on people unfamiliar with our disposition.” Citing the example of a

biological male who had applied for permission to marry a man after undergoing a series of feminizing operations, she declared: "I mention this case because it shows that one really must lay down limits to one's desires. . . . It is never possible to fulfill all of one's desires, and we must not remove ourselves from this principle."⁶⁴ Weis's restrictive tone is again typical of middle-class transvestite discourse, which prioritized social respectability over radical change. Yet her skepticism toward individuals who sought full transformation of their physical and legal status was not universal, with other commentators displaying a more open-minded attitude toward the role that science and medicine might play in defining a transvestite identity and politics.

Respectability through Science

Interwar Germany was at the forefront of international sexual research, not least thanks to Hirschfeld's renowned Institute for Sexual Science in Berlin.⁶⁵ Although only a few individuals had access to the pioneering surgical and hormonal technologies being developed at such progressive institutions, the exciting possibilities of this research were gaining currency via the mainstream media. In magazines and newspapers such as the widely circulated *Berliner Illustrierte Zeitung* or the popular monthly *Uhu*, scientific developments were alternately explained, lampooned, and celebrated, from antiaging hormone treatments to Eugen Steinach's "sex change" experiments on rats and other animals.⁶⁶ Within this context, the TV media provided an important forum for discussing the relevance of medical and scientific developments for trans-identifying individuals.

Science provided a basis for arguing that transvestism was a naturally occurring condition, and as Hirschfeld's homosexual rights activism had shown, if phenomena such as homosexuality could be shown to be natural and harmless, rather than infectious or degenerate perversions, then a case could be made for political inclusion on that basis.⁶⁷ Contributors with specialist knowledge, including Hirschfeld and Karsch-Haack, wrote articles for the TV media in which they "translated" for lay readers scientific findings in fields such as endocrinology. Readers in turn critically discussed these findings, from the potential applications of the Steinach experiments or Abderhalden blood tests (which suggested a biological basis for transvestism), to the pros and cons of undergoing voluntary castration. Some also reported on personal experiences as sexological patients: one reader described undergoing medical tests at the University of Halle in order to apply for a change of name, with his/her blood shown to contain "gender-specific elements of both sexes."⁶⁸ Weimar-era transvestites thus showed themselves to be anything but passive receptacles of medical knowledge trapped in Foucauldian hierarchies of power; rather, as Harry Oosterhuis has demonstrated of the subjects of Krafft-Ebing's sexological case studies, they "responded to social constraints in different ways, reflected upon them, and reconstituted them in the light of their particular circumstances."⁶⁹ Their discussions reflect not only a strong

commitment to a broader bourgeois faith in science and medicine, but also a belief that this commitment could be used to bolster the case for transvestite respectability.⁷⁰

A key moment in these subcultural discussions was the Lili Elbe case in the early 1930s. Danish artist Lili Elbe, formerly Ejnar Wegener, had traveled to Germany to have surgery under Professor Warnekross of Dresden, following a series of hormone treatments and a period of living full time as a woman. Thanks to the posthumous publication of Elbe's autobiography, *Ein Mensch wechselt sein Geschlecht* (1932, translated into English as *Man into Woman*, 1933), this soon became the most famous instance in interwar Germany of surgery performed on the basis of what would now be recognized as a "transsexual" identification. It was not, however, the first such case: sexologists since the early 1910s had observed attempts by male-to-female transvestites at self-castration, facial hair epilation, and paraffin injections into the breasts; in 1912 surgeon Richard Mühsam reported on an early female-to-male surgery removing breasts and uterus; while in 1920/21 one of the first attempts at male-to-female surgery was made at Hirschfeld's Institute. These early surgical techniques were developing hand in hand with reconstructive and cosmetic surgery methods for war veterans, and in some cases were accompanied by early attempts at hormone therapy.⁷¹ Although there are few detailed accounts within the contemporary medical literature, possibly due to the laws prohibiting castration, there is evidence that multiple surgeries of this nature were performed.⁷²

The TV media covered Elbe's case in detail, linking medical advances to the political priorities of the larger transvestite community. New BfM leader Paul Weber, who had succeeded Radszuweit in 1932, explained that this was a case of "particularly strongly developed hermaphroditism," in which female hormones that had shown up on a blood test were to be "supported" through the surgical implantation of a new gonad system. Weber used Elbe's experience in order to highlight the everyday struggles facing non-gender-normative individuals, including the bureaucracy involved in name-change applications, and drew on his position of influence to encourage readers to become politically active:

Which transvestite who reads about this . . . is not seized by the thought: why am I not in her shoes? Certainly, not every transvestite is a hermaphrodite, or more clearly expressed, not every transvestite possesses secondary sex characteristics like Lilli Elven [sic], which could induce a scientist to perform this not unperilous operation. But even if one is not prepared to go so far with one's wishes, the fact remains that there are still things in Germany today in relation to transvestism that are strongly in need of reform.⁷³

Such commentary suggests a growing sympathy within subcultural circles toward individuals seeking physical transformation by surgical and hormonal means. Following

Elbe's death from complications in late 1931, Weber again wrote for the "Welt der Transvestiten," this time to reiterate the positive potential of sex transformation surgeries in the face of such a tragic event. He noted promising signs emerging from one Berlin hospital—presumably Hirschfeld's institute—where similar operations to that undergone by Elbe were producing good results, citing the example of a former (male) transvestite who was now enjoying a postoperative holiday, "needless to say as a complete woman."⁷⁴

Weber's support for transsexual surgeries was echoed by readers, some of whom had read Elbe's autobiography, and who emphasized the life-and-death stakes of such cases:

Yes, I envied her twofold, firstly because Lili was able to have the sex transformation performed that for years I have longed for, but which insufficient finances prevent me from undergoing. Secondly, Lili was allowed to die, and to die as a woman, while the likes of us must struggle our way through life, because we are too cowardly to put an end to this useless existence.⁷⁵

Such statements show not just sympathy with Elbe's plight, but acknowledgement by readers of their own transsexual desires, suggesting a shift by the late Weimar period toward greater acceptance of individuals who sought to surgically align their bodies with their gender identity. Demonstrating what Judith Halberstam describes as "clear transsexual fantasies and cross-identifications" historically earlier than their widespread medical or surgical realization, these 1930s sources foreshadow the development of a more clearly articulated "transsexual" identity following World War II.⁷⁶

Weimar and Beyond

In Germany, it would be at least another two decades before transsexual surgical techniques became widely available, with Hirschfeld's institute one of the first victims of Nazi ransacking in 1933.⁷⁷ While this did not put a complete stop to medical interventions,⁷⁸ or even to social events such as transvestite balls, from as early as 1932 homosexual and transvestite bars began to be forcibly closed, while the publications examined here did not survive beyond the spring of 1933. Following the "Röhm-Putsch" and subsequent homosexual purges from Nazi ranks, male-to-female transvestites were frequently caught up in the dramatically increased prosecution of male homosexuals under Paragraph 175. This intensified with the foundation in 1936 of the Reich Office for Combating Homosexuality and Abortion, which oversaw the registration of transvestites, and in some cases imprisonment, forced castration, and even death in the concentration camps.⁷⁹

The next recorded attempts at transgender political organization occurred a war and an ocean away, in 1950s USA, where Virginia Prince led a group of transvestites in

producing the newsletter *Transvestia*, “arguably the first overtly political transgender publication in US history.”⁸⁰ Although the establishment of sex reassignment clinics in that country attracted a degree of sympathetic coverage in the West German media, transvestites’ status in the divided Germanies was possibly even more marginal than it had been in the Weimar era.⁸¹ In their study of sex-gender subcultures in Hamburg, Rosenkranz et al. observe that while female imitators continued to enjoy considerable popularity in the clubs and cabarets in the Adenauer era, they were closely observed and often persecuted by the morals police, with the courts ordered to make liberal use of laws allowing transvestites to be sentenced to the workhouse.⁸² Not until 1976 in the GDR and 1981 in the FRG were laws passed allowing individuals to undergo “sex change” surgeries and apply for a change of name and gender status on their birth certificates, thereby bringing about some of the changes that had first been fought for under the Weimar Republic. The so-called *Transsexuellengesetz* (“transsexual law”) passed into West German law at this time remains in force today, and continues to be the focus of transgender activism: as recently as 2011, the federal constitutional court changed the controversial Article 8 to remove the genital surgery requirement.⁸³

Transgender politics, as Susan Stryker observes, challenges conventional understandings of what constitutes political activity within modern society, addressing “the very configurations of body, sense of self, practices of desire, modes of comportment, and forms of social relationships that qualify one in the first place as a fit subject for citizenship.”⁸⁴ Germany’s Weimar Republic saw not only the crystallization of a new identity category, “the transvestite,” but also the beginnings of a self-conscious, politically active counterpublic organizing around that identity. From today’s perspective, the exclusionary tactics employed by members of these middle-class organizations in the interest of establishing themselves as “respectable” citizens worthy of political recognition, not least the demand that all transvestites adhere to bourgeois standards of “decency” in dress and behavior, often seem blatantly discriminatory. Nonetheless, these organizations and media outlets deserve recognition as one of the first examples of public activism by and for trans-identifying individuals anywhere in the world, offering members and readers a sense of belonging, a forum for debate, and a platform for political change.

Notes

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1. All translations from German sources are my own. The term “male-to-female transvestite” refers to biological males who identify as feminine, and is a translation of (*männlicher*) *Transvestit*. Likewise, “female-to-male transvestite” refers to a female-born individual who identifies as masculine, and is a translation of *Transvestitin*. As it is not always possible to establish whether the individuals in question preferred the male or female pronoun, I follow Meyerowitz in using “the

- pronouns that accord with a person's public presentation of gender": Joanne Meyerowitz, *How Sex Changed: A History of Transsexuality in the United States* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2002), 13.
2. "Unsere Leser haben das Wort: Angeklagter in Frauenkleidung," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 5, no. 13, September 25, 1929 (issues of *Die Freundin* were unpaginated).
 3. Magnus Hirschfeld, *Die Transvestiten: Eine Untersuchung über den erotischen Verkleidungstrieb* [1910], 2nd ed. (Leipzig: Ferdinand Spohr, 1925). On the transition from "inversion" to "homosexuality" see Michel Foucault, *The History of Sexuality 1: The Will to Knowledge* (London: Penguin, 1998); George Chauncey Jr., "From Sexual Inversion to Homosexuality: The Changing Medical Conceptualization of Female 'Deviance,'" in *Passion and Power: Sexuality in History*, ed. Kathy Peiss et al. (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1989), 87–117.
 4. Havelock Ellis, *Eonism and Other Supplementary Studies* (Philadelphia: Davis, 1919); Ferdinand Karsch-Haack, "Jungesellin und Jungeselle (die Transmutistin)," *Garçonne* 4 (1931): 1–4; Max Marcuse, "Ein Fall von Geschlechtsumwandlungstrieb," *Zeitschrift für Psychotherapie und medizinische Psychologie* 6 (1916): 176–93.
 5. This was notwithstanding criticism in both scientific and subcultural circles that the term was too focused on dress, although Hirschfeld insisted it encompassed a range of gendered expressions: Magnus Hirschfeld, *Sexuelle Zwischenstufen: Das männliche Weib und der weibliche Mann* (Bonn: Marcus & Webers, 1922), 129–30, 140–42.
 6. Rainer Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts: Transvestitismus und Transsexualität in der frühen Sexualwissenschaft* (Giessen: Psychosozial-Verlag, 2005).
 7. Vern L. Bullough and Bonnie Bullough, *Cross Dressing, Sex, and Gender* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1993), 280.
 8. Although Herrn discusses the importance of the transvestite media, his primary focus is on sexology. Other research has focused overwhelmingly on the work of Hirschfeld and Ellis, see, e.g., Darryl Hill, "Sexuality and Gender in Hirschfeld's *Die Transvestiten*: A Case of the 'Elusive Evidence of the Ordinary,'" *Journal of the History of Sexuality* 14, no. 3 (2005): 316–32; Ivan Crozier, "Havelock Ellis, Eonism and the Patient's Discourse; or, Writing a Book about Sex," *History of Psychiatry* 11 (2000): 125–54.
 9. Michael Warner, "Publics and Counterpublics," *Public Culture* 14, no. 1 (2002): 87.
 10. Much of this campaigning was under the auspices of the *Wissenschaftlich-humanitäres Komitee*, founded in 1897 and led by Hirschfeld until the late 1920s: Manfred Baumgardt, "Die Homosexuellen-Bewegung bis zum Ende des Ersten Weltkrieges," in *Eldorado: Homosexuelle Frauen und Männer in Berlin 1850–1950. Geschichte, Alltag und Kultur*, ed. Michael Bollé (Berlin: Rosa Winkel, 1984), 17–27.
 11. On the "gross mischief" laws see Robin Lenman, "Germany," in *The War for the Public Mind: Political Censorship in Nineteenth-Century Europe*, ed. Robert Justin Goldstein (Westport: Praeger, 2000), 61; on their application to transvestites see Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 65–66; and on the police force's widespread powers of interference see Victoria Harris, *Selling Sex in the Reich: Prostitutes in German Society, 1914–1945* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010), 153–55.
 12. For the full report of this case see Hirschfeld, *Transvestiten*, 192ff. Herrn discusses the transvestite certificates and name change applications in detail, noting that reports in sexological journals suggest that the practice was widespread: *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 63–69, 85ff., 126–27, 139 (on transvestite passports); 140 (on Simon).
 13. Hirschfeld, *Transvestiten*, 363, cited in Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 66.
 14. Harris, *Selling Sex*, 149ff.; Julia Roos, *Weimar Through the Lens of Gender: Prostitution Reform, Woman's Emancipation, and German Democracy, 1919–33* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2010), 179–83. For a broader account of police modernization see Richard Bessel, "Militarisierung und Modernisierung: Polizeiliches Handeln in der Weimarer Republik," in "Sicherheit"

- und "Wohlfahrt": Polizei, Gesellschaft und Herrschaft im 19. und 20. Jahrhundert, ed. Alf Lütke (Frankfurt/Main: Suhrkamp, 1992), 323–43.
15. Hsi-Huey Liang, *The Berlin Police Force in the Weimar Republic* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1970), 22–23.
 16. Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 134–40.
 17. Polizei Präsidium Dept. IV 1922, 347, cited in Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 136.
 18. Hans Ostwald, *Männliche Prostitution im kaiserlichen Berlin* [1906] (Berlin: Janssen, 1992).
 19. In June 1930, for example, a gathering of transvestites and male homosexuals was harassed by members of the Berlin police sporting organization, prompting an outraged response from homosexual leader Friedrich Radszuweit: "Homosexuelle schlagen Polizeibeamte nieder!" *Die Freundin* 6, no. 31, July 30, 1930.
 20. See, e.g., John D'Emilio, "Capitalism and Gay Identity," in *Powers of Desire: The Politics of Sexuality*, ed. Ann Snitow et al. (New York: Monthly Review, 1983), 100–113; George Chauncey, *Gay New York: Gender, Urban Culture, and the Makings of the Gay Male World, 1890–1940* (New York: Basic Books, 1994).
 21. Manfred Baumgardt, "Das Institut für Sexualwissenschaft und die Homosexuellenbewegung in der Weimarer Republik," in *Eldorado*, 31–43; James Kollenbroich, *Our Hour Has Come: The Homosexual Rights Movement in the Weimar Republic* (Saarbrücken: VDM, 2007); Marti Lybeck, "Gender, Sexuality, and Belonging: Female Homosexuality in Germany 1890–1933" (Ph.D. diss., University of Michigan, 2007), 290ff.
 22. The founding of these groups is reported in *Die Freundin* 3, no. 2, February 7, 1927; and vol. 5, no. 12, September 18, 1929.
 23. The subtlety of this name, which referenced an eighteenth-century cross-dressing French diplomat, was aimed at protecting members' privacy: Marie Weis, "Die Aufgaben der Vereinigung D'Eon," in "Der Transvestit," *Garçonne* no. 4, 1930, 10.
 24. "Meinungsaustausch der Transvestiten," in *Die Freundin* 3, no. 8, May 2, 1927.
 25. In response to this fear, the organizations instituted policies such as addressing members by pseudonyms and sending mail in plain envelopes. On problems facing the transvestite organizations see also Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 142ff.
 26. Ilse P., "Bitte um Rat," in "Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 7, no. 22, June 3, 1931. Personal advertisements in these periodicals came from as far away as Boston. On the similar role played by homosexual periodicals in combating isolation, see, e.g., Kirsten Plötz, *Einsame Freundinnen: Lesbisches Leben während der zwanziger Jahre in der Provinz* (Hamburg: MännerschwarmSkript, 1999).
 27. "Die Welt der Transvestiten" appeared in the BfM-affiliated *Die Freundin* (Girlfriend) from 1924 to 1933 (sometimes called "Der Transvestit" [Transvestite] or "Meinungsaustausch der Transvestiten" [Transvestite forum]). "Der Transvestit" appeared from 1926 to 1932 in the DfV-affiliated *Frauenliebe* (Womanly love) (later renamed *Garçonne*). On the relationship between the transvestite and female homosexual periodicals see also Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 152, 156; Lybeck, "Female Homosexuality," 350–51; for a broader profile of the latter, including censorship issues, see Heike Schader, *Virile, Vamps und wilde Veilchen: Sexualität, Begehren und Erotik in den Zeitschriften homosexueller Frauen im Berlin der 1920er Jahre* (Königstein: Helmer, 2004), 42–82.
 28. Published from 1930 to 1932, this magazine attracted considerable attention in homosexual sister publications such as *Die Freundin* or *Der Insel*, but is not currently accessible in German archives. Radszuweit's earlier plans to establish a monthly periodical called *Transvestiten* did not come to fruition.
 29. On the middle-class orientation of organizations such as the BfM see Glenn Ramsay, "The Rites of Artgenossen: Contesting Homosexual Political Culture in Weimar Germany," *Journal of the History of Sexuality* 17, no. 1 (2008): 85–109; Lybeck, "Female Homosexuality."

30. Letter by Toni Simon, *Die Freundin* 5, no. 13, September 25, 1929. Chancellor von Bülow's 1897 speech to the Reichstag in which he outlined the goal of achieving for Germany its supposedly rightful, if belated, "Platz an der Sonne" can be found in Rüdiger vom Bruch und Björn Hofmeister, eds., *Deutsche Geschichte in Quellen und Darstellung: Band 8. Kaiserreich und Erster Weltkrieg 1871–1918* (Stuttgart: Reclam, 2000), 268–70. For a discussion of this policy in the context of the "Eulenburg affair," the homosexual scandal that rocked the Kaiser's ranks, see James Steakley, *Die Freunde des Kaisers: Die Eulenburg-Affäre im Spiegel zeitgenössischer Karikaturen* (Hamburg: MännerschwarmSkript, 2004), 23–24.
31. George L. Mosse, *Nationalism and Sexuality: Respectability and Abnormal Sexuality in Modern Europe* (New York: Fertig, 1985), 16.
32. Marie Weis, "Bericht über die . . . Zusammenkunft der transvestitischen Interessengemeinschaft 'D'Eon,'" *Garçonne* no. 1, 1930, 14.
33. Lina Es, "Meinungsaustausch der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 3, no. 8, May 2, 1927.
34. Marie Weis, "Die Aufgaben der Vereinigung D'Eon," in "Der Transvestit," *Garçonne* no. 4, 1930, 10.
35. Emi von Wolters, "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 7, no. 22, June 3, 1931.
36. *Frauenliebe*, for example, in which "Der Transvestit" appeared, reported a circulation figure of 10,000: *Sperlings Zeitschriften- u. Zeitungs-Adreßbuch: Handbuch der deutschen Presse* (Leipzig: Börsenverein der Deutschen Buchhändler, 1928), 384.
37. See, e.g., Erna, "Vom Rat zur Tat," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 5, no. 7, August 14, 1929; Hilde G., "Was uns Not tut!" *Die Freundin* 5, no. 21, November 20, 1929.
38. This series by Emi Wolters ran in *Die Freundin*'s "Welt der Transvestiten" column from February to April 1932.
39. Mosse, *Nationalism and Sexuality*, 22.
40. Criminal anthropologist Cesare Lombroso, for example, had profiled cross-dressers as degenerate "delinquents"; see Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 29. On the ongoing power of degeneration discourses in 1920s Germany see Laurie Marhoefer, "Degeneration, Sexual Freedom, and the Politics of the Weimar Republic, 1918–1933," *German Studies Review* 34, no. 3 (2011): 529–49.
41. "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 7, no. 21, May 27, 1931; Käte Karl, "Der Transvestit," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 5, no. 5, July 31, 1929.
42. Lybeck, "Female Homosexuality," 284, 319, 330, 344. On similar tendencies in male homosexual organizations at this period see Ramsay, "The Rites of Artgenossen."
43. "Und abends spielt er die Dame," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 6, no. 35, August 27, 1930; Marie Weis, "Bericht über die . . . Zusammenkunft," *Garçonne* 1 (1930): 14.
44. E. Raven, "Das Empfindungsleben der Transvestiten," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 8, no. 45, November 9, 1932.
45. Ellen van Derk, "Meinungsaustausch über Modefragen," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 3, no. 16, August 22, 1927; see also Irene von D., "Muß das sein?" *Die Freundin* 8, no. 6, February 10, 1932. There is a potential irony in this fetishization of gender "realness" that apparently went unquestioned within the TV media, although it may have played a role in the more overtly performative world of contemporary female impersonators. For a recent critique of the "realness" imperative see Judith Halberstam, *In a Queer Time and Place: Transgender Bodies, Subcultural Lives* (New York: New York University Press, 2005), 51–52.
46. See, e.g., Annemarie Groverius, "Meinungsaustausch über Modefragen: Die Frau in Hosen," *Die Freundin* 3, no. 15, August 8, 1927.
47. "Die Transvestiten und die Polizei," in "Der Transvestit," *Die Freundin* 1, no. 7, November 15, 1924.
48. Sandy Stone, "The Empire Strikes Back: A Posttranssexual Manifesto," in *The Transgender Studies Reader*, ed. Susan Stryker and Stephen Whittle (New York: Routledge, 2006), 230.
49. PEM, *Heimweh nach dem Kurfürstendamm* (Berlin, 1962), cited in Andreas Sternweiler,

- "Schwules Selbstbewusstsein," in *Goodbye to Berlin? 100 Jahre Schwulenbewegung*, ed. Schwules Museum und Akademie der Künste (Berlin: Rosa Winkel, 1997), 125.
50. Sternweiler, "Schwules Selbstbewusstsein," 125, also 123–28.
 51. Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 143; Adele Meyer, ed., *Lila Nächte: Die Damenklubs im Berlin der zwanziger Jahre* (Berlin: Lit. Europe, 1994); Jürgen Müller and Helge Schneberger, "Schwules Leben in Köln," in *Verführte Männer: Das Leben der Kölner Homosexuellen im Dritten Reich*, ed. Cornelia Limpricht et al. (Cologne: Volksblatt, 1991), 11; Frank Sparing, "... wegen Vergehen nach §175 verhaftet": *Die Verfolgung der Düsseldorfer Homosexuellen während des Nationalsozialismus* (Düsseldorf: Grupello, 1997), 23–24.
 52. An exception was E. K., "Meinungsaustausch der Transvestiten," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 3, no. 13, July 11, 1927.
 53. On the sexological neglect of female-to-male transvestites see Geertje Mak, "'Passing Women' im Sprechzimmer von Magnus Hirschfeld: Warum der Begriff 'Transvestit' nicht für Frauen in Männerkleidern eingeführt wurde" (transl. Mirjam Hausmann), *Österreichische Zeitschrift für Geschichtswissenschaften* 9, no. 3 (1998): 384–99.
 54. For a queer reading of Hahn's transgressive persona see Lybeck, "Female Homosexuality," 351–68.
 55. Hansi, "Die Welt der Transvestiten," in *Die Freundin* 8, no. 23, June 8, 1932.
 56. Judith Halberstam, *Female Masculinity* (Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press, 1998), 141–73; Gayle Rubin, "Of Catamites and Kings: Reflections on Butch, Gender, and Boundaries," in *The Transgender Studies Reader*, 471–81.
 57. A common estimate in the TV magazines was that ten percent of male-to-female transvestites were homosexual. On Hirschfeld's attempts to separate transvestism from homosexuality see Hill, "Sexuality," 316–332.
 58. Mosse, *Nationalism and Sexuality*, 37–42; Baumgardt, "Institut für Sexualwissenschaft," 31–43; Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 38–41.
 59. R. C., "Meinungsaustausch der 'Transvestiten,'" *Die Freundin* 3, no. 11, June 13, 1927; Loni Rex, "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 6, no. 43, October 22, 1930.
 60. I am indebted to the GSR reader for this argument.
 61. Hansi, "An O.," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 7, no. 42, October 21, 1931; "Bericht über die Veranstaltung . . .," in "Der Transvestit," *Garçonne* 6, 1930, 10.
 62. "Bericht über die Transvestitenversammlung [sic]," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 5, no. 18, October 30, 1929.
 63. Although Hirschfeld coined the term "seelischen Transsexualismus" ("spiritual transsexualism") in 1923, he used it, observes Meyerowitz, in a quite different way from current understandings: Meyerowitz, *How Sex Changed*, 19.
 64. Marie Weis, "Über die inneren Voraussetzungen," *Frauenliebe* 2 (1931): 4.
 65. On the institute's transvestite-related activities, see Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 111ff., 120–26, and 167–218 for details of surgical procedures.
 66. Satirical references to the Steinach experiments can be found, for example, in the reader competition: "Was sagen Sie bloß zu Fräulein Mia? Das Ergebnis unserer Preisfrage," *Berliner Illustrierte Zeitung* 51, December 18, 1927, 2127. On the experiments themselves see Eugen Steinach and Josef Loebel, *Sex and Life: Forty Years of Biological and Medical Experiments* (London: Faber, 1940).
 67. Chandak Sengoopta, "Glandular Politics: Experimental Biology, Clinical Medicine, and Homosexual Emancipation in Fin-de-siècle Central Europe," *Isis* 89 (1998): 445–73.
 68. T. F., "Meinungsaustausch der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 3, no. 13, July 11, 1927; see also Emi von Wolters's account of being one of Hirschfeld's earliest cases: *Die Freundin* 7, no. 26, 1931.
 69. Harry Oosterhuis, *Stepchildren of Nature: Krafft-Ebing, Psychiatry, and the Making of Sexual Identity* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2000), 12.

70. Paul Weindling, "Bourgeois Values, Doctors, and the State: The Professionalization of Medicine in Germany 1848–1933," in *The German Bourgeoisie*, ed. David Blackbourn and Richard J. Evans (London: Routledge, 1991), 198–223.
71. Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 103–9, 167ff., 175ff., 191–94; see also Sander Gilman, "Das Gesicht wahren: Zur ästhetischen Chirurgie," in *Gesichter der Weimarer Republik*, ed. Claudia Schmölders and Sander Gilman (Cologne: Dumont, 2000), 96–112.
72. Herrn provides details of at least six operations performed at Hirschfeld's institute, but notes that they only produced one scientific publication: Felix Abraham, "Genitalumwandlung an zwei männlichen Transvestiten," *Zeitschrift für Sexualwissenschaft* 18 (1931): 223–26 (cited in Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 197).
73. Paul Weber, "Aus Mann wird Frau," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 7, no. 13, April 1, 1931. On Elbe see also Herrn, *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 204–11.
74. Paul Weber, "Lili Elbe tot!," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 7, no. 39, September 30, 1931.
75. K. Peters, "Gedanken eines Transvestiten," in "Die Welt der Transvestiten," *Die Freundin* 7, no. 43, October 28, 1931.
76. Halberstam, *Female Masculinity*, 86. While some scholars date the emergence of a transsexual identity to the 1940s, Halberstam and others rightly criticize this chronology as too late and too rigid; see also Jay Prosser, "Transsexuals and the Transsexologists: Inversion and the Emergence of Transsexual Subjectivity," in *Sexology in Culture: Labelling Bodies and Desires*, ed. Lucy Bland and Laura Doan (Cambridge: Polity, 1998), 118–27.
77. Baumgardt, "Institut für Sexualwissenschaft," 35–38.
78. Herrn describes an operation that took place in 1939 in Mannheim: *Schnittmuster des Geschlechts*, 216; see also 157–65.
79. Burkhard Jellonek, *Homosexuelle unter dem Hakenkreuz: Die Verfolgung von Homosexuellen im Dritten Reich* (Paderborn: Schöningh, 1990), 22ff.; Günter Grau, ed., *Hidden Holocaust? Gay and Lesbian Persecution in Germany 1933–1945* (London: Cassell, 1995), 103ff.; Bernhard Rosenkranz, Ulf Bollmann, and Gottfried Lorenz, *Homosexuellen-Verfolgung in Hamburg 1919–1969* (Hamburg: Lambda, 2009), 19ff.
80. Susan Stryker notes that Prince's network similarly limited membership to heterosexual males: *Transgender History* (Berkeley: Seal, 2008), 46–47, 55.
81. "Geschlechtsumwandlung: Schöner Frühling," *Der Spiegel*, no. 39, September 19, 1966, <http://www.spiegel.de/spiegel/print/d-46414609.html>. On the development of sex reassignment clinics see Friedemann Pfäfflin, "Sex Reassignment, Harry Benjamin, and Some European Roots," *The International Journal of Transgenderism* 1, no. 2 (1997), <http://www.symposion.com/ijt/ijt0202.htm>.
82. Rosenkranz et al., *Homosexuellen-Verfolgung*, 129–32.
83. Herbert Prantl, "Das gefühlte Geschlecht," *Süddeutsche Zeitung*, January 28, 2011, <http://www.sueddeutsche.de/politik/verfassungsgericht-kippt-transsexuellengesetz-das-gefuehlte-geschlecht-1.1052344>. On the East German situation see *Transsexualismus damals in der DDR* (dir. Michael Mayr, 2010).
84. Stryker, *Transgender History*, 51.